Exhibition Planner

A practical workbook for artists preparing an exhibition — from first idea to the records you keep afterwards.

Use this planner on paper or fill it in digitally. It follows the life of a show: defining the idea, agreeing terms with the venue, planning the budget and timeline, installing, opening — and documenting everything so the exhibition becomes a permanent part of your archive.

GARF is a charity working for the protection of artists' legacy. This planner is free to use, copy and share.

Exhibition: _____

Artist: _____

1. Define your exhibition

A clearly stated idea guides every later decision — works, budget and communication.

Working title

Format (solo / group / online / site-specific)

Intended venue or platform

Theme or central idea — what holds the works together?

Target audience

Desired outcome (sales, visibility, research, funding)

Goals

Write down what you would like to happen at this exhibition, or as a result of it. A goal you can name is a goal you can plan for.

The works

List the works you intend to show. If your catalogue is in the Registry, note each work's GAWID reference — it keeps the exhibition linked to your permanent archive.

#	Title	Year	GAWID reference	Status
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

2. Venue and agreement

Questions to settle with the venue — in writing — before you commit.

If you exhibit anywhere but your own studio, get a written, signed agreement. No exceptions. If the venue has no contract, write a summary of what you agreed and send it by email — it protects you both.

The venue

- [ ] Name and address of the venue, and your main contact person
- [ ] Exhibition dates, opening hours, and date and time of the reception
- [ ] Is the opening private (RSVP) or open to the public?
- [ ] Floor plan of the space — where is it, and who has it?
- [ ] Installation and deinstallation dates and procedures
- [ ] Who installs the work? What tools and technical support are available?
- [ ] Electrical outlets, extension routes, lighting, and any equipment needed

The terms

- [ ] Written contract or letter of agreement signed by both parties
- [ ] Commission on sales, and any discount shared with the venue
- [ ] Artist's fee or honorarium, if any
- [ ] Who pays for shipping, insurance, framing and the reception?
- [ ] Insurance: who covers the works in transit and on the wall, and for what value?
- [ ] Who designs, pays for and sends the announcements — and the deadline for your information?
- [ ] What happens to unsold works, and when must they be collected?

Responsibilities

The venue is responsible for

I am responsible for

3. Timeline

A twelve-month countdown — compress or stretch it to fit your show.

Most exhibitions are planned over one to two years; some come together in six months. Enter your own dates in the right-hand column and work backwards from the opening.

When	Key tasks	My date
12 months	Define theme and goals; draft budget; research funding; confirm venue	
9–12 months	Begin or continue making the work; source materials and framing quotes	
6 months	Sign the agreement; confirm insurance and shipping arrangements	
3 months	Design invitations; draft press release; photograph works for promotion	
6–8 weeks	Send press release and listings; confirm catalogue or handout texts	
4 weeks	Send invitations; plan the reception; confirm installation schedule	
1 week	Condition-check and pack works; prepare labels and price list	
Install	Deliver, install, light and label; photograph the installation	
Opening	Reception; guest book or sign-up sheet; record visitors and press	
After	Deinstall; inspect returned works; record sales; update your archive	

4. Budget

What the show will cost, and what it might bring in.

A companion spreadsheet (GARF_Exhibition_Budget.xlsx) with these categories and automatic totals is available from the same page as this planner.

Costs

Item	Estimate	Actual
Materials and production		
Framing and presentation		
Shipping and transport		
Insurance		
Printing: invitations, labels, catalogue		
Promotion and advertising		
Reception (refreshments, staff)		
Installation materials and equipment hire		
Travel and accommodation		
Contingency (about 10%)		
Total costs		

Income

Source	Estimate	Actual
Artist's fee or honorarium		
Grants and funding		
Sales (after venue commission)		
Other		
Total income		

5. Installation and opening

The week it all becomes real.

Before delivery

- [ ] Every work condition-checked and photographed
- [ ] Packing labelled outside with title, your name and handling notes
- [ ] Delivery date, time and access confirmed with the venue
- [ ] Handover receipt or loan form prepared for signature on delivery
- [ ] Labels printed: title, year, medium, dimensions, price or NFS
- [ ] Price list and inventory list printed for the venue desk

Installation day

- [ ] Tools and hanging kit brought or confirmed on site
- [ ] Works placed, hung, lit and labelled
- [ ] Installation photographed — these views belong in your archive
- [ ] Walk-through with the venue contact; agree any last changes in writing

The opening

- [ ] Guest book or sign-up sheet at the door
- [ ] Card reader or payment process tested, if you handle sales
- [ ] Someone asked to photograph the event
- [ ] Press and special guests greeted; contact details collected

6. After the show

An exhibition is not finished when the works come down.

Within two weeks

- [ ] Inspect every returned work; note and photograph any damage
- [ ] Record sales, gifts and new owners in your catalogue
- [ ] Add the exhibition to your CV and to each work's exhibition history
- [ ] File the agreement, receipts, press and installation photographs together
- [ ] Follow up enquiries and thank the venue, helpers and funders

In your GARF archive

If you keep your catalogue in the Registry, record the exhibition there: title, venue, dates, the works shown, installation views and the exhibition text. The show then becomes a permanent, verifiable part of your artistic record — preserved for researchers, and for your heirs.

Notes — what worked, what to do differently

This planner is a practical aid, not legal, insurance or financial advice.